

Looking beyond the silver lining

Yogesh Kathuniya talks about **overcoming** personal and health challenges as he strives for gold at the 2024 Paris Paralympics.

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This past month, India has had a close brush with the bittersweet emotions that come with finishing second. Neeraj Chopra missed out on a gold medal at the Paris Olympics, falling short by 3.52m. The same happened at the Lausanne Diamond League a little over two weeks later, with a deficit of 1.12m denying him the top spot once again. His face of utter disappointment on both occasions was something that's hard to forget.

6,568 km away, in New Delhi, para discus thrower Yogesh Kathuniya could empathise. Ever since he won silver at the Tokyo Summer Games, Yogesh has found himself stuck one step away from the middle of the podium in international events.

"I won't lie," he tells *Sportstar*, ahead of the 2024 Paris Paralympics. "I was quite happy with how I performed in Tokyo. It was my biggest medal until that point. After that, a lot of things changed. My family was happy. I had a good throw there that could have bumped me to the gold medal position, but it ended up being a foul."

"I got silver here (Tokyo), I got a bronze



before (Dubai World Championships in 2019), so I thought going forward, I would get that gold medal. But then, in the World Championship in 2023 in Paris, the Asian Games in Hangzhou before that, and this year at the Kobe World Championships, I got back-to-back silver medals. That demotivated me a bit. I wasn't able to satisfy myself, even if others were happy with what I was doing."

Yogesh recalls countless conversations he's had with himself in front of the mirror, despite technically doing the job — winning a medal.